

STACK RANKED

A Game of Corporate Ascension

Synergy Corp — Disrupting Disruption Since Whenever™

2–6 Players · 60–90 Minutes · Ages 14+

An engine-building career-ladder game of performance reviews, mandatory trainings, and quiet workplace despair.

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Quick Start

New to Synergy Corp? Here's the entire game in four steps. Everything else in this rulebook is detail.

1. **Stand-Up Meeting:** collect Productivity and Political Capital from your tableau (plus 1 free Productivity just for showing up). Then pick up a Project card from the Kanban Board into your Backlog — mandatory if it's empty, optional (you may skip) if you already have at least one; you're just claiming it, not paying for it yet.
2. **Sprint:** spend your Action Points to Hire a Skill card, Work a Project (pay to finish any one entry in your Backlog — your choice which), Network, or Self-Care. You may also take one Overtime action per round for a bonus Action Point.
3. **Lunch:** draw an Office Chaos card and resolve it.
4. **Postmortem:** refill the boards and pass the First Player token. Every 3rd round is a Quarterly Performance Review — the top performer(s) may get promoted, the bottom performer(s) get a warning.

First player to be promoted into CEO wins. That's it — the rest is how to get there without burning out.

Welcome to Synergy Corp

You started in the mailroom — metaphorically, or possibly literally, HR was vague about it. Somewhere above you, seven layers of management stand between you and the corner office, and every one of them got there the same way you're about to try: performance reviews, strategic networking, and a truly heroic tolerance for mandatory training videos.

Synergy Corp doesn't make anything anyone can quite explain. It disrupts. It pivots. It once acquired a competitor specifically to shut down the product line customers actually liked. None of that is your problem. Your problem is Career Capital, Political Capital, and not having a Burnout Crisis in front of the VP of Product.

Objective

Climb the Career Ladder from Intern to CEO before anyone else does. You'll do this by completing Projects and building a professional network — both feed your Career Capital, the permanent score that determines whether you're actually eligible for promotion. Everything else — Skill cards, Political Capital, even your quarterly Review Score — exists to help (or hurt) that climb.

Components

- 1 Career Ladder board (7 rungs, Intern through CEO)
- 6 Player Desk mats
- 6 wooden pawns
- 42 Skill/Tool cards (30 unique designs across 3 tiers)
- 37 Project cards (31 unique designs, including a 13-card evergreen pool — headlined by Reduce Technical Debt — that fills the Kanban Board's permanent 5th slot)
- 30 Office Chaos cards
- 12 Mandatory Training cards
- 16 Management Style cards
- Productivity cubes, Political Capital chips, Burnout track cubes (0–10 per player)
- Career Capital trackers and Quarter Marker cubes (one pair per player)
- Compliance Badge tokens, PIP tokens, and Employee-of-the-Quarter tokens
- This rulebook

Deck Composition

The appendix lists every unique card once. On the table, some cards appear in multiple physical copies so the decks don't run dry:

Deck	Unique Designs	Physical Copies	Notes
Skill/Tool — Tier 1	12	24 (×2 each)	Available from Round 1
Skill/Tool — Tier 2	10	10 (×1 each)	Shuffled in from Quarter 3
Skill/Tool — Tier 3	8	8 (×1 each)	Shuffled in from Quarter 5
Project — Early	6	12 (×2 each)	Available from Round 1
Project — Mid	6	6 (×1 each)	Shuffled in from Quarter 3
Project — Late	6	6 (×1 each)	Shuffled in from Quarter 5
Project — Evergreen	13	13 (×1 each)	Own pool feeding the Kanban Board's permanent 5th slot — every design carries a Burnout cost; the slot is never removed from the board
Office Chaos	30	30 (×1 each)	Reshuffle discards when depleted
Mandatory Training	12	12 (×1 each)	Reshuffle discards when depleted
Management Style	16	16 (×1 each)	Reshuffle discards when depleted
Feedback (<i>variant</i>)	18	18 (×1 each)	9 Positive / 9 Constructive — reshuffled fresh each Review (see Variant Rules)

Key Concepts

The Three Live Resources

Productivity (P). Your output. Spend it to Hire Skill/Tool cards and to Work Projects. Productivity does not carry Career Capital by itself — it's what you convert into Career Capital.

Political Capital (PC). Your visibility and relationships. Gained mainly through Networking. Spent on nothing directly — it's compared at every Performance Review and decides the CEO Board Vote, so hoarding it is a legitimate strategy.

Burnout (0–10). Your risk track. Rises from Overtime, some Skill cards, some Projects, and Office Chaos. At 10, you suffer a Burnout Crisis: reset to 6, lose 2 Political Capital, and skip your next Sprint entirely.

The Two Permanent Trackers

Career Capital (CC). Your real, permanent résumé score. It only ever goes up — fed by completed Projects (a lot) and Networking (a little, but steadily). Every promotion is gated by a Career Capital threshold. Nothing ever removes it.

Compliance Badges. A minor counter from Mandatory Training. Director requires 2 Badges; VP requires 4. Nobody has ever been promoted primarily because of their Badges, but you cannot be promoted without them.

The Quarter Marker

Each player has a second cube that sits on their Career Capital track, marking where their CC was as of the last Performance Review. The gap between your current CC and your Quarter Marker is how much you've actually grown this Quarter — and it's the heart of your Review Score (see [Quarterly Performance Review](#)). Move your Quarter Marker to match your current CC at the end of every Review.

Your Backlog

Your Backlog is every Project you've picked up but haven't paid for yet. There's no limit to how many you can hold. If it's ever empty, picking up a card from the Kanban Board at Stand-Up isn't optional — the Backlog can never stay at zero. If you already have at least one entry, though, you may choose to pick up another anyway or skip it for the round (see [6.1](#)). Taking a task is free; paying its Productivity cost is what actually finishes it and earns the reward, and that only happens on your Sprint, via Work a Project (see [6.2](#)) — Stand-Up only ever adds to your Backlog, never lets you pay for anything in it. When you Work a Project, you choose which Backlog entry to pay off — cheapest, most valuable, whatever suits you — and if you have enough Action Points and Productivity, you can clear more than one in the same Sprint. Ignore your Backlog for too long, though, and it just keeps growing.

Setup

1. Place the Career Ladder board where everyone can reach it. Each player takes a Desk mat, a pawn (placed on Intern), and starts with 0 Productivity, 0 Political Capital, 0 Burnout, 0 Career Capital, 0 Compliance Badges, and an empty Backlog.
2. Shuffle the Management Style deck. Each player draws 1 card and keeps it face-up — everyone should be able to see everyone's boss.
3. Shuffle the Tier 1 Skill/Tool cards and reveal 5 to form the Job Board.
4. Shuffle the Early Project cards and reveal 4 to form the Kanban Board, alongside a card drawn from the 13-card evergreen pool (headlined by Reduce Technical Debt) as a permanent 5th slot.
5. Shuffle the Office Chaos deck and the Mandatory Training deck separately. Place both face-down within reach.
6. Give each player a Quarter Marker cube and place it on Career Capital position 0, right alongside their main tracker.
7. Determine the first player: whoever had the most recent performance review in real life goes first. If nobody can agree, whoever currently holds the most impressive-sounding made-up job title takes the token.

How to Play a Round

A round has four phases, always in this order. Every player resolves each phase before anyone moves to the next.

6.1 — Stand-Up Meeting (Income Phase)

Simultaneously, every player collects the Productivity and Political Capital shown on their Skill/Tool tableau, plus a flat +1 Productivity "showed up" bonus.

Then, in First Player order (this part isn't simultaneous — everyone's reaching for the same Kanban Board): if your Backlog is empty, you must take one Project card from the Kanban Board — your Backlog can never stay at zero. If you already have at least one Backlog entry, you may take another if you want, or skip and leave your Backlog exactly as it is this round. There's no cap either way — a Backlog can grow as large as you're willing to let it.

Taking a card is free; you are not paying its cost yet, just claiming it. Taking it empties that slot exactly as if you'd completed a Project there (a regular slot stays empty until the next Postmortem refills it; the Evergreen slot instantly deals itself a replacement — see [Deck Composition](#) — which is why there's always something to pick up even if every other slot is already spoken for this Stand-Up). Whatever cost is showing on the card at the moment you take it (including any Scope Creep it had already picked up) is locked in for that entry — it won't creep any higher while it sits in your Backlog, even though the slot that replaces it will start accruing its own Scope Creep from scratch.

Stand-Up never lets you pay for anything in your Backlog — that only happens on your Sprint, via Work a Project.

6.2 — Sprint (Action Phase)

In First Player order, each player spends Action Points one at a time. Your Action Point budget depends on your current rung:

Rung	Action Points
Intern / Software Engineer	2
Team Lead / Manager	3
Director / VP / CEO	4

Each Action Point buys one of the following:

- **Hire** — pay a Skill/Tool card's Productivity cost to take it from the Job Board. One-Shot cards resolve immediately and are discarded; Permanent cards join your tableau.
- **Work a Project** — choose any one entry in your Backlog (see [Your Backlog](#)) and pay its Productivity cost. This is the only way to actually pay for and finish a task — Stand-Up only ever adds to your Backlog, never pays for anything in it. Gain the Career Capital reward (and any other listed effects) immediately, then that entry is gone. You choose which entry to Work — cheapest, most valuable, whatever — and if you have enough Action Points and Productivity, you can Work more than one entry in the same Sprint. Unavailable

only if your Backlog is completely empty (rare — Stand-Up adds an entry every round).

- **Network** — no cost. Gain 2 Political Capital and 1 Career Capital.
- **Self-Care** — no cost. Remove 2 Burnout.

Once per round, before or after your normal Action Points, you may also take Overtime: gain 1 extra Action Point to spend this round, but gain 2 Burnout.

Scope Creep

Any Project that sits unclaimed on the board for 2 full rounds has its Productivity cost increased by 1 (its reward never changes). The deadline moves. The budget doesn't. This does not apply to the Kanban Board's Evergreen slot.

6.3 — Lunch

Draw the top card of the Office Chaos deck and resolve it exactly as written.

6.4 — Postmortem

Refill the Job Board and Kanban Board back up to their full size, and pass the First Player token clockwise. Every 2nd Quarterly Review (after rounds 6, 12, 18, and so on), before the next round's Stand-Up Meeting, every player simultaneously draws and resolves a Mandatory Training card.

Quarterly Performance Review

Every 3rd round (rounds 3, 6, 9...) is a Quarterly Performance Review. Resolve these steps in order:

Step 1 — Calculate Review Score

Review Score = (Career Capital gained since your Quarter Marker) + (Political Capital on hand) + (Feedback held — variant rule) – (Burnout ÷ 4, rounded down).

This rewards real output delivered this Quarter and current visibility — not just whoever happens to be holding the most cash at the buzzer.

Step 2 — CEO Board Vote

Any player at VP whose Career Capital is 78 or more is a Board Vote candidate. If there is exactly one candidate, they become CEO immediately — the game ends after this round. If there are multiple candidates, whoever holds the most Political Capital on hand wins the vote and becomes CEO. (Yes: a VP who was never anyone's top performer can still win the vote and take the corner office. Several early playtest groups found this personally upsetting. We left it in.)

Step 3 — Standard Promotions

Determine promotion slots for your player count (see [Player Count Adjustments](#)). Among players who meet their next rung's Career Capital requirement (and Badge requirement, if any) — excluding anyone already crowned CEO this Review — the highest Review Score(s), up to the number of slots, are promoted one rung.

Eligible players who aren't selected this time don't lose anything. Instead they become Employee of the Quarter: gain 1 Political Capital immediately and keep a token (worth bonus points in the Advanced Variant — see [Winning the Game](#)).

A promotion always moves you up **exactly one rung** — you climb the ladder one level at a time and can never skip a level, no matter how dominant your Review Score is. (The only door to the top rung, CEO, is the Board Vote in Step 2, and it only opens for players already sitting at VP.)

Step 4 — PIP and Demotion

Among players not promoted or crowned this Review, the lowest Review Score(s) — up to the PIP slot count — receive a PIP token. A player who already holds a PIP token instead loses it and is demoted one rung. A player being demoted from Intern instead enters Freelance Purgatory: skip the entire next Quarter's Sprints (you still draw Office Chaos and Training), then return to Intern with a clean slate.

Step 5 — Reset

Every player moves their Quarter Marker to match their current Career Capital. Burnout, Career Capital, and Compliance Badges persist. Anyone promoted or demoted draws a new Management Style card.

Mentorship Bonus

Any player whose rung is 2 or more behind the current leader gains +1 Political Capital every Stand-Up Meeting, until they close the gap. Synergy Corp calls this a mentorship program. It is, mechanically, a rubber band.

The Career Ladder

Rung	Action Points	Career Capital to Promote In	Badges Required
0 — Intern	2	—	—
1 — Software Engineer	2	8	—
2 — Team Lead	3	18	—
3 — Manager	3	30	—
4 — Director	4	44	2
5 — VP	4	60	4
6 — CEO	4	78 + Board Vote	—

Promotion slots per Quarterly Review: 1 for games of 2–5 players, 2 for games of 6 players. PIP slots always match the number of promotion slots.

Management Styles

At setup, and again every time you're promoted or demoted, you draw a Management Style card and keep it face-up on your Desk mat. It's a passive, asymmetric power that lasts until your next promotion or demotion — for better or (usually) worse.

Full text for all 16 Management Style cards is in the [Card Reference Appendix](#). A few highlights:

- The Actually Supportive Manager is the only card in the deck with no drawback. Everyone will be suspicious of whoever draws it.
- The Micromanager and The Founder Who Refuses to Delegate both look like upgrades and both come with a catch that shows up on your very next turn.
- The Seagull Manager and The Mushroom Manager both punish being ignored by leadership — one through random bursts of collateral damage, the other by quietly starving you of Political Capital while your Productivity climbs.
- The Peter Principle is the only card that touches Action Points directly: it freezes them at 2 forever, no matter how many times you get promoted.
- Getting promoted or demoted always means a new boss. There is no version of this game where you keep the manager you liked.

Winning the Game

The base game ends the instant a player is crowned CEO via the Board Vote (finish the current round for fairness, then stop). That player wins.

Advanced Variant: The Long Game

For a more strategic, less race-focused experience, play a fixed 8 Quarters (24 rounds) instead of racing to CEO. At the end of Round 24, calculate a Final Score for each player:

Final Score = (Rung $\times$ 10) + (Career Capital $\div$ 2) + (Political Capital on hand) – Burnout + (5 $\times$ Employee-of-the-Quarter tokens).

Highest Final Score wins — even if nobody ever reaches CEO. This variant rewards consistent, well-rounded play over a single lucky Board Vote.

Player Count Adjustments

2 Players

Play proceeds exactly as normal — 1 promotion slot, 1 PIP slot. With only one rival, the promotion race gets noticeably more personal (and more petty).

6 Players

Use 2 promotion slots and 2 PIP slots per Review (already reflected in the Career Ladder table). Additionally, reveal a second row of 5 Job Board cards (10 total) so the market doesn't dry up with more players competing for the same Skill cards.

Variant Rules (Optional): Feedback & Collaboration

Two optional rules add more player interaction. Both are **on by default** in the digital version (toggle them off, or tune them, in the game's rule settings); for the tabletop game, agree to use them before Setup.

The Feedback Deck

Shuffle the 18-card **Feedback** deck: **9 Positive** ("Exceeds Expectations", "Highly Visible Impact"...) and **9 Constructive** ("Room for Growth", "Let's Circle Back on This"...). Keep it as a separate face-down pile.

At the start of every Quarterly Performance Review, before scoring:

1. Shuffle the deck and **deal one Feedback card to each player**, face-up.
2. Going around in First Player order, each player either **keeps** their card or **gives it to any other player**. (You'll keep the glowing praise; you'll hand the "constructive" card to whoever's about to outshine you.)
3. Each Feedback card a player is holding is worth **±2 political points** in *this* Review only — added to your Review Score (and to the CEO Board Vote if you're a VP). Positives are +2, Constructive are -2. Your **net feedback is capped at ±4** per Review, and it evaporates when the Quarter resets.

It's a rubber-band: the person having the best Quarter tends to collect the bad-feedback pile. Deal with it.

Feedback style — pick one before Setup (or in the digital game's setup screen):

- **Standard Feedback** (*default*) — exactly the procedure above: one card each, keep or hand it off.
 - **360° Review** — a secret, simultaneous variant that plays like a real peer-review cycle: Because you can't help yourself and must play one card, the natural move is to slip your Constructive card to whoever's ahead and bin the praise — so the front-runner reliably eats a (still ±4-capped) pile of bad feedback, while a generous player *can* choose to gift the Positive to a friend. Same math as Standard, more knives. This mode is **balance-neutral** vs Standard (see the Designer's Notes) — choose it for table feel, not for advantage.
1. Deal every player **two** cards: **one Positive and one Constructive**.
 2. Each player secretly chooses **one** of their two cards to **give to another player** (you can never keep it yourself) and **discards the other**. Place the card you're giving **face-down** in front of its recipient.
 3. When everyone has chosen, **flip all the cards face-up at once**, then score them the same way (±2 each, net capped at ±4, this Review only).

Collaborative Projects

Projects can be tackled as a team.

- On your Sprint you may **open** one of your backlog Projects for collaboration (free — it doesn't cost an Action Point).
- Any player, on *their* Sprint, may spend an Action Point to **contribute Productivity** to an open Project. Contributions add up across turns until they reach the Project's cost, then it's completed.
- **When a shared Project ships, the Career Capital is split among the contributors in proportion to the Productivity each one paid.** The original owner instead takes **Political Capital equal to max(Project**

CC – 2, 1 — a coordinator's reward *in lieu of* a Career-Capital share (and the owner must have chipped in at least 1 Productivity to earn it). The owner also takes the Project's Burnout and any Compliance Badge.

- If a single *other* player funds the whole thing alone, they simply complete it and take the full reward as if it were their own.

Collaboration lets a cash-strapped player finally land an expensive Project, and lets a Productivity-rich player convert a surplus into Career Capital by pitching in — while the owner banks the political goodwill.

Designer's note. *These two rules were balance-tested over tens of thousands of simulated games (see the card-faithful harness `stack_ranked_montecarlo.js` and the writeup below).*

*With the default settings they leave all five archetypes viable — in fact tighter than the base game — while making it a little easier to come back from behind. The naïve "owner gets CC **and** PC / dump every bad card on the leader" version hands the political specialist a runaway lead, so the defaults cap the feedback swing, credit shared Career Capital to whoever actually did the work, and aim bad feedback at whoever's topping the current Review. The **360° Review** feedback style was measured against Standard the same way (3,000 games/cell): with the default targeting it's **balance-neutral** — the five archetypes land in the same order and the same 14–33% band (std-dev 7.0pp for both), and comebacks and runaway-leader rates are indistinguishable. It changes how the table feels (secret, simultaneous, everyone throws exactly one card), not who wins, because the ± 4 net cap already bounds the biggest possible swing in either style. So pick it for the drama, not an edge.*

Card Reference Appendix

Every unique card in the game, in full. Cards marked One-Shot resolve immediately and are discarded; everything else is Permanent and joins your tableau until the game ends.

Skill / Tool Cards — Tier 1 (Cost 1–3, available from Round 1)

Name	Cost	Type	Effect	Flavor
Copy-Paste from Stack Overflow	1	Permanent	+1 Productivity/round.	It worked on someone else's machine in 2019. Good enough.
Ctrl+F Power User	1	Permanent	+1 Productivity/round.	Never reads past the first match.
Free Snack Hoarder	1	Permanent	+1 Political Capital/round.	Keeps granola bars in every drawer for emergency morale trades.
Office Plant Whisperer	1	Permanent	+1 Political Capital/round.	The only living thing in the office that's thriving.
Reply-All Enthusiast	2	One-Shot	Immediately: every other player gains 1 Burnout; you gain 2 Political Capital.	Accidentally cc'd the whole company on a lunch order question. Iconic.
Emotional Support Rubber Duck	2	Permanent	Once per Quarter, take Overtime without gaining Burnout.	It just listens. That's more than your manager does.
"Let's Take This Offline"	2	Permanent	+1 Political Capital/round. Once per Quarter, resolve a Mandatory Training without losing next round's Action Point (you still gain the Badge).	Bought yourself three weeks. The meeting still happens eventually.
Standing Desk Enthusiast	2	Permanent	+1 Productivity/round. Ignore Burnout gained from Office Chaos cards.	Won't stop talking about it, but their back does feel great.
LinkedIn Thought Leader	2	Permanent	+2 Political Capital/round; –1 Productivity/round.	Posted "Hot take: communication is important." 40,000 impressions.
Regex Whisperer	3	Permanent	+3 Productivity/round; +1 Burnout/round.	Nobody else can read their code. That's job security, right?
Actually Reads the Documentation	3	Permanent	+1 Productivity/round. Your Projects cost 1 less Productivity (minimum 1).	A hero nobody asked for.
Master of Small Talk	3	Permanent	+2 Political Capital/round.	Knows everyone's dog's name. Cannot recall a single deadline.

Skill / Tool Cards — Tier 2 (Cost 4–5, shuffled in from Quarter 3)

Name	Cost	Type	Effect	Flavor
Scrum Master	4	Permanent	+2 Political Capital/round; –1 Productivity/round.	Facilitates a 45-minute meeting to schedule a 15-minute meeting.
Full-Stack, Full-Burnout	4	Permanent	+3 Productivity/round; +1 Burnout/round.	Owns the frontend, backend, database, and the on-call phone.
AI Prompt Engineer	4	Permanent	+3 Productivity/round. Each time an Office Chaos card is drawn, flip a coin; on heads, discard 2 Productivity from your bank (a confident hallucination).	Confidently hallucinated the entire Q3 roadmap.
Toxic Positivity Certification	4	Permanent	+2 Political Capital/round. You may not take Self-Care actions.	Everything is a learning opportunity, including this.
The Brilliant Jerk	5	Permanent	+4 Productivity/round; –1 Political Capital/round.	Ships incredible code. Has made three people cry this quarter.
Master Delegator	5	Permanent	+2 Productivity/round; +2 Political Capital/round.	Has not personally touched a keyboard since 2021.
Buzzword Compiler	4	Permanent	+2 Political Capital/round; –1 Productivity/round.	Synergizes core competencies to leverage actionable takeaways.
Whiteboard Diagram Enthusiast	4	Permanent	+2 Productivity/round. If you have 4+ Skill cards in play, your Projects cost 1 less Productivity.	The diagram has 14 boxes. Nobody knows what 6 of them mean.
On-Call Pager Veteran	5	Permanent	+2 Productivity/round. Ignore the first Burnout you'd gain each Quarter.	Has slept through three fire drills and one actual fire.
Imposter Syndrome (Actually Very Competent)	4	Permanent	+2 Productivity/round; +1 Political Capital/round.	Is, statistically, doing better than they think.

Skill / Tool Cards — Tier 3 (Cost 6–8, shuffled in from Quarter 5)

Name	Cost	Type	Effect	Flavor
The Bus Factor of One	6	Permanent	+3 Productivity/round. If you suffer a Burnout Crisis, lose double the usual Political Capital penalty.	If they quit, nothing ships again. Ever.
Golden Handcuffs (Fully Vested)	7	Permanent	Ignore all PIP and demotion effects for the rest of the game.	The stock options mature in 18 months. So does nothing else.
Rolodex of Every VP	7	Permanent	+4 Political Capital/round.	Knows a guy. Always knows a guy.
Ships It Friday at 5 PM	6	One-Shot	Immediately complete one Project on the Kanban Board at half its listed Productivity cost (round up).	The demo gods are watching. Ship it and pray.

Name	Cost	Type	Effect	Flavor
The Exit Interview Isn't Scary Anymore	6	One-Shot	Immediately remove all your Burnout and gain 1 Compliance Badge.	Says everything they wish they'd said in every performance review — on the way out the door.
The Fixer	8	Permanent	Whenever any other player suffers a Burnout Crisis, gain 2 Political Capital.	Somehow always available exactly when someone else's project catches fire.
VP Whisperer	7	Permanent	+3 Productivity/round; +2 Political Capital/round.	Gets meetings on the calendar that shouldn't be mathematically possible.
Golden Parachute Clause	8	One-Shot	Hold this card face-down in front of you. The next time you would be demoted, discard this instead and ignore the demotion.	Negotiated on the way in. Nobody remembers why.

Project Cards — Early (Cost 2–4)

Name	Cost (P)	Reward	Flavor
Update the README (Nobody Reads It Anyway)	2	3 Career Capital.	Now technically documented.
Fix the Bug in Production (On a Friday)	3	4 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	It's fine. Everything is fine.
Onboard the New Hire	3	3 Career Capital; +1 Political Capital.	They seem nice. Give it two Quarters.
Clean Up the Shared Drive	2	3 Career Capital.	Found 40 folders named 'final_FINAL_v2.'
Respond to the Simple Support Ticket	2	2 Career Capital; +1 Political Capital.	It was a browser cache issue. It's always a browser cache issue.
Write the Sprint Retro Notes	4	5 Career Capital.	Action items: none of these will happen.

Project Cards — Mid (Cost 5–6, shuffled in from Quarter 3)

Name	Cost (P)	Reward	Flavor
Migrate the Legacy Codebase	6	8 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	Nobody who wrote the original code still works here.
Launch the Feature Nobody Asked For	5	7 Career Capital.	It tested well with exactly one user: the VP's nephew.
Respond to the RFP (Due Tomorrow, Started Today)	5	6 Career Capital; +1 Political Capital.	Yes, we can absolutely do all of this by Q2.
Survive the Compliance Audit	6	7 Career Capital; 1 Compliance Badge.	Everyone suddenly remembers where the fire extinguishers are.
Rebuild the CI/CD Pipeline (Third Time's the Charm)	6	8 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	This one's permanent. Definitely. For real this time.
Run the All-Hands Presentation	5	6 Career Capital; +1 Political Capital.	Slides are just screenshots of Slack messages, but with a logo now.

Project Cards — Late (Cost 7–9, shuffled in from Quarter 5)

Name	Cost (P)	Reward	Flavor
Ship the Major Redesign Before the Conference	8	11 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	The demo gods are watching. They are not merciful.
Turn Around the Failing Division	9	13 Career Capital.	Everyone competent already quietly left. You didn't get the memo in time.
Land the Whale Client	8	11 Career Capital; +2 Political Capital.	They want it fully custom, half price, by Friday.
Lead the Company-Wide Reorganization	9	13 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	Nobody's title changed, but everyone's manager did. Twice.
Present to the Board (12 Minutes to Justify a Department)	7	10 Career Capital; +2 Political Capital.	They looked at their phones for eleven of them.
Negotiate the Vendor Contract (40 Pages of Terms)	7	10 Career Capital.	Nobody read past page 3. That's where the bad clause is.

Project Cards — Evergreen Pool (Cost 1–8; every design carries a Burnout cost)

The Kanban Board's 5th slot never empties. Whichever card sits there is drawn from this 13-card pool; when it's claimed, discard it and immediately draw the next card from the pool into the same slot (reshuffling the discards back in if the pool runs out). The same card may come up again, or a different one may take its place — either way, the slot is always occupied by *some* Evergreen Project, and it's always exempt from Scope Creep.

Name	Cost (P)	Reward	Flavor
Reply to the Jira Comment From Six Months Ago	1	1 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	The person who filed it left the company in Q2. The ticket did not.
Answer a "Quick Question" on Slack	2	3 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	That was forty-five minutes ago. There are now six people in the thread.
Delete the Commented-Out Code From 2019	2	2 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	It's not documentation. It was never documentation.
Un-harden the Hardcoded Value	3	3 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	Replaced "prod-server-3" with a config flag that defaults to "prod-server-3."
Rotate the API Keys You Forgot About	3	4 Career Capital; +2 Burnout.	Rotated three keys. Broke a fourth integration nobody remembered existed.
Reduce Technical Debt	4	5 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	Perpetually 80% done. It has always been 80% done. It will always be 80% done.
Bump the Node Version (Nothing Breaks. Probably.)	4	4 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	247 transitive dependencies quietly disagree.
Consolidate the Three Config Files Into One (Now Four)	4	4 Career Capital; +2 Burnout.	Progress, technically.

Name	Cost (P)	Reward	Flavor
Untangle the Legacy Spaghetti (One More Time)	5	6 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	Found a comment that says "DO NOT REMOVE, NOT SURE WHY." Removed it anyway.
Archive the Zombie Microservice	5	7 Career Capital; +2 Burnout.	Nobody knows what calls it. Everybody's afraid to find out.
Migrate Off the Framework You Migrated To Last Year	6	7 Career Capital; +1 Burnout.	The last migration's postmortem recommended this framework.
Squash 40 Commits Into "misc fixes"	6	8 Career Capital; +2 Burnout.	git blame now blames everyone equally.
Finally Read the Incident Postmortem Action Items	8	10 Career Capital; +2 Burnout.	Item 1: "Add more monitoring." Filed fourteen months ago. Still open.

Office Chaos Cards (30)

Name	Effect	Flavor
Reply-All Apocalypse	Every player gains 1 Burnout.	247 replies. 246 said "please remove me from this thread."
All-Hands Meeting (Could Have Been an Email)	Every player loses 1 Productivity from this round's income.	It was, in fact, an email.
Layoffs Loom (Just a Rumor... Probably)	Every player gains 1 Burnout. The First Player gains 1 Political Capital out of sheer relief.	HR scheduled a "quick chat." Nobody is calm.
Quiet Quitting Goes Mainstream	Any player may decline their Overtime option this round to remove 1 Burnout instead.	Doing exactly what's in the job description. Revolutionary.
Free Bagel Friday	Every player gains 1 Political Capital.	Cinnamon raisin again. Someone doesn't respect the group chat's preferences.
Fire Drill	The player who used Overtime most recently gains 1 Burnout.	Now standing in a parking lot with 200 coworkers you've never seen before.
Surprise Reorg	Everyone returns their Management Style card. Shuffle the Management deck and deal each player a new one.	Nobody's job changed. Everybody's manager did.
Engagement Survey (Anonymous, Allegedly)	Every player gains 1 Political Capital.	Question 14: 'I feel my work is valued.' Strongly Disagree.
The Office Dog Visits	Each player may remove 1 Burnout.	Best coworker on the payroll. Unfortunately unpaid.
New CEO Announced	Each player with 5 or more Skill cards in play discards 1 of their choice.	New broom, new org chart, same problems.
WiFi Dies Mid-Demo	The First Player loses 1 Productivity.	The client watched a loading spinner for four minutes.
Snack Wall Restocked	Every player gains 1 Productivity.	Someone's hoarding the good granola bars again.
The Chair Finally Gets Fixed	Every player may remove 1 Burnout.	After 11 months and 4 support tickets. A quiet miracle.

Name	Effect	Flavor
Casual Friday Goes Full Week	Every player gains 1 Political Capital.	Nobody knows what 'business casual' means anymore. Everyone's relieved.
Unlimited PTO (Policy, Not Practice)	No player may use the Self-Care action this round.	Technically infinite. Practically, someone will ask why you're taking it.
Company Offsite in Cancun	The First Player gains 2 Productivity. Every other player gains 1 Burnout (FOMO).	Mandatory fun. Fully mandatory.
IT Outage	Skip the Income Phase for every player this round.	The ticket says 'Priority: Urgent.' The queue says 'Position: 214.'
Late-Night CEO Email	Every player gains 1 Burnout.	Sent 11:47 PM. Subject line: 'Quick thought '
Company-Wide Chat Outage	No player may take the Network action this round.	Turns out everyone was just Slacking each other from three feet away.
Corporate Wellness Session	Every player may remove 1 Burnout, but loses 1 Productivity this round.	A 20-minute breathing exercise squeezed between two deadlines.
Viral Hustle Culture Post	Every player immediately resolves a Mandatory Training card, out of the normal cycle.	'Sleep is for people who don't want it badly enough' — 2.1M likes.
A Colleague's Job Interview (Elsewhere)	Each player chooses: gain 2 Political Capital (you covered for them), or gain 2 Productivity (you quietly took their tasks).	They 'have a dentist appointment.' Everyone knows.
Open-Floor-Plan Renovation	Every player gains 1 Burnout.	Now you can hear every phone call within 40 feet. Great for focus.
Catered Lunch (Actually Good This Time)	Every player gains 1 Productivity and 1 Political Capital.	The good taco place. Morale is measurably higher.
Server Room Overheats	Whoever has the most Skill cards in play loses 1 Productivity.	It's always the one player with the biggest tableau.
The Standing Desk Convert	Each player who owns "Standing Desk Enthusiast" gains 1 extra Political Capital.	They will tell you about it regardless.
The Spreadsheet Leaks Early	Every player gains 1 Political Capital.	Someone found next Quarter's ranking spreadsheet. Everyone's recalculating.
Everything Is On Fire (Metaphorically, Probably)	Whoever has the most Burnout gains 1 more Burnout. Every other player gains 1 Political Capital in sympathy.	It's always the same person's fire.
Therapy Benefit Actually Gets Used	Any one player may remove 2 Burnout.	Covered at 60% after the deductible. Still worth it.
National Cybersecurity Awareness Month (It's Also October)	Every player gains 1 Compliance Badge.	The phishing test email had 12 typos. 30% of the company still clicked it.

Mandatory Training Cards (12)

Unless otherwise noted, every Training card is "Standard": you lose your first Action Point next round, and gain 1 Compliance Badge.

Name	Effect	Flavor
Anti-Harassment Training (The Annual Awkward One)	Standard.	Same video. Same actor. Somehow one year older each time.
Cybersecurity Awareness: You Clicked the Phishing Link	Standard, plus +1 Burnout.	The email was from 'IT Department.' It had a countdown timer.
Data Privacy Training (Promises Retention By Lunch)	Standard.	GDPR, CCPA, and six acronyms nobody in the room can define.
DEI Refresher Course	Standard.	The same slide deck as last year, with a new date in the corner.
Fire Safety Procedures (Nobody Remembers)	Standard.	The evacuation map on the wall is for a building that no longer exists.
The Team Retreat (Trust Falls Included)	Standard, plus +1 Burnout.	Someone did not get caught. It has changed the team dynamic permanently.
Information Security Awareness Month	Standard.	Coincidentally also National Cybersecurity Awareness Month. Nobody planned this. Everyone's annoyed regardless.
New Manager Training ("Good Luck" Sendoff)	Gain 2 Compliance Badges instead of the usual 1.	Four hours on feedback techniques. Zero minutes on the raise you were promised.
Bias Workshop (Everyone Assumes It's About Someone Else)	Standard.	Full attendance. Zero self-recognition.
Phishing Simulation Test (People Actually Failed)	Standard. Additionally, whoever has the least Political Capital also gains 1 Burnout.	23% company-wide click rate. HR is 'concerned.'
Ethics Training (Sponsored By the Thing That Caused It)	Standard.	Scheduled the same week as the news story. Nobody mentions the news story.
Unconscious Bias Training, Redux	Standard, plus +1 Political Capital.	The sequel nobody asked for. Somehow longer than the original.

Management Style Cards (16)

Name	Effect	Flavor
The Micromanager	Your first Action each round must be Work a Project if you can afford one; otherwise it is wasted.	Wants a status update on the status update.
The Absentee Boss	Gain 1 free Action Point each round. You may not take the Network action — your boss is never around to introduce you to anyone.	Hasn't reviewed a time-off request since the reorg. Or approved one. Or seen one.
The Credit-Stealing Boss	Whenever you complete a Project, lose 1 Career Capital but gain 1 Political Capital (sympathetic coworkers notice).	Presented your work at the all-hands. Used the word 'we' a lot. Meant 'I.'
The Chaotic Pivot-Happy Visionary	At the start of each Quarter, flip a coin: heads, gain 2 Productivity; tails, discard 1 Skill card.	The strategy changed twice during this sentence.
The Yes-Man Exec	Hiring Skill cards costs 1 less Productivity (minimum 1). Mandatory Training costs you 2 lost Action Points next round instead of 1.	Agreed with the last three people who talked to him. In the same meeting.

Name	Effect	Flavor
The Actually Supportive Manager	Gain 1 Political Capital every Income Phase. No drawback.	Asked how you're doing and waited for the actual answer. Suspicious, but in a good way.
The Results-at-Any-Cost Boss	Overtime grants +1 extra Productivity, but also +1 extra Burnout, on top of its normal effect.	Doesn't care how you hit the number. Cares extremely if you don't.
The Buzzword Machine	Network grants +1 extra Political Capital. Your Projects cost 1 more Productivity — nobody can define the deliverable.	Wants to double-click on synergies before we boil the ocean.
The Founder Who Refuses to Delegate	Gain 1 free Action Point each round. Self-Care costs 2 Action Points instead of 1.	"We're moving fast" has justified everything since 2019.
The Tenure-Not-Talent Manager	Compliance Badges count double toward promotion requirements. Hiring Skill cards costs 1 more Productivity.	Been here 14 years. Still can't use the new expense software.
The Seagull Manager	At the start of each Quarter, flip a coin: heads, every other player gains 1 Burnout — you swooped in and stirred things up; tails, you gain 1 Political Capital — you flew off before anyone noticed.	Flies in, makes a lot of noise, craps on the roadmap, and is gone before the retro.
The Mushroom Manager	+2 Productivity/round (fed on nothing, somehow still growing); -1 Political Capital/round (kept in the dark — nobody tells you anything).	Kept in the dark and fed manure. Thriving, weirdly.
The Peter Principle	Your Action Points are always 2, no matter your rung — promoted well past their competence. Hiring Skill cards costs 1 less Productivity (overcompensates by throwing tools at the problem).	Promoted three times. Still can't find the deploy script.
The Always-On Boss	Overtime grants +1 extra Burnout, on top of its normal effect (always expects a same-night reply). Self-Care costs 2 Action Points instead of 1 (there's no such thing as fully logging off).	Texts you at 11 PM. Reacts with a to your out-of-office reply.
The Nepotism Hire	+2 Political Capital/round (knows people); Hiring Skill cards costs 1 more Productivity (couldn't approve a headcount request to save their life).	Turns out the CEO is their uncle. Nobody has said this out loud.
The Consultant-Turned-Manager	Your Projects cost 1 less Productivity (loves a framework for everything); -1 Political Capital/round (nobody trusts the person who charges by the hour).	Drew a 2x2 matrix. Nobody asked for the 2x2 matrix.

Feedback Cards (18, variant rule)

Dealt one per player at the start of each Quarterly Review, then kept or given away; each card held is worth its value in political points that Review (net capped at ± 4). See **Variant Rules** above.

Positive Feedback (9 — worth +2 each)

Name	Value	Flavor
Exceeds Expectations	+2	Hit every goal and then invented three more to hit. Nobody asked, but here we are.

Name	Value	Flavor
Goes Above and Beyond	+2	Answered a Slack at 2 a.m. once. It comes up in every review now.
A True Team Player	+2	Brought donuts to the retro. The retro was about layoffs, but still.
Highly Visible Impact	+2	The dashboard is green. Nobody checks what it measures, but it's green.
Strong Executive Presence	+2	Says 'let me push back on that' with total confidence and no follow-up.
Consistently Delivers	+2	Delivers consistently, if not necessarily what was asked for.
Great Culture Add	+2	Laughs at the CEO's jokes at exactly the right volume.
Promotion-Ready	+2	Has been promotion-ready for six quarters. The ladder is just crowded.
The Team Depends on Them	+2	Load-bearing employee. HR has flagged this as a risk, admiringly.

Constructive Feedback (9 — worth -2 each)

Name	Value	Flavor
Needs to Improve Communication	-2	Sends a 400-word Slack that could have been 'ok.' Or vice versa.
Struggles with Ambiguity	-2	Asked for 'requirements.' In this economy.
Not a Culture Fit	-2	Logs off at 5. Suspicious. Un-American, even.
Lacks Executive Presence	-2	Said 'I don't know' in a meeting. Out loud. On purpose.
Room for Growth	-2	Endless, breathtaking room. Vistas of it. So much room.
Doesn't Take Feedback Well	-2	Took the feedback fine. Just didn't agree, which is worse.
Siloed and Territorial	-2	Owns the one system nobody else understands. Weirdly protective of the job security.
Missed Key Deliverables	-2	The deliverable was 'vibes.' The vibes were, per the review, off.
Let's Circle Back on This	-2	We will not be circling back. We both know that.

Designer's Notes: Balancing Stack Ranked

This game was tuned the same way you'd tune any economy: build bots that play fixed, extreme strategies, run tens of thousands of games, look at what breaks, and fix it. Three iterations were run, 20,000 games each, always with one of each of five archetypes seated at the same table — Grinder (projects only), Politician (networking only), Workaholic (projects plus reckless Overtime), Cautious (safety-first generalist), and Balanced (does a bit of everything). All numbers below are the actual output of the simulator included with this game (simulate.py), not hand-picked estimates.

v1 — The Baseline (and its very broken AND-gate)

The first version gated every promotion behind two completely independent lifetime stats: cumulative Productivity ever spent on Projects, AND cumulative Political Capital ever earned through Networking. Both had to individually clear a threshold. It seemed reasonable on paper.

It was not reasonable in practice. Grinder never networks, so its lifetime Political Capital stat sat at zero forever — permanently ineligible for any promotion no matter how many Projects it finished. Politician never works a Project, so its lifetime Productivity stat stayed at zero — same problem, opposite resource. Workaholic, despite its extra Action Points, also never networks and was equally stuck. Three of five archetypes were mathematically incapable of ever being promoted.

Result: Balanced won 68.0% of games and Cautious won 32.0% — the only two archetypes that ever touch both resources. Grinder, Politician, and Workaholic won a combined 0.0%. Games also dragged: an average of 66.8 rounds, because for most of the game only two of the five players at the table could legally advance at all.

There's an accidental joke buried in this bug that we liked enough to think about seriously: the simulation kept showing Grinder as the top quarterly scorer by raw output, then getting passed over for promotion anyway because it had never once networked. We didn't plan that. Stack ranking did that to itself.

v2 — Unify the Gate (partial fix)

The obvious repair: stop requiring two independent stats and replace them with one unified Career Capital track, fed by both completed Projects (a lot per completion) and Networking (a little, but repeatable), with a fallback so a promotion slot checks the next-highest scorer instead of vanishing when the top scorer doesn't qualify.

Result: Politician climbed from mathematically impossible to a real, if weak, 4.6%. Average game length dropped from 67 rounds to 32.5, since Career Capital now accumulates from two directions instead of one. But Grinder and Workaholic were still stuck at 0.0% and 0.0% — unifying the gate hadn't fixed them at all.

Digging into the per-round logs turned up a second, subtler bug: the Quarterly Review Score used to decide who gets the (limited) promotion slot only counted leftover banked Productivity and Political Capital — and a pure producer spends essentially all of their Productivity buying Projects, every single round. Grinder and Workaholic were quietly banking more Career Capital than anyone else at the table while posting the worst quarterly "optics" of anyone, every single Quarter, because their bank balance always looked empty right when it mattered. They were never being blocked by the gate anymore — they just never got a turn at it.

v3 — Fix the Scorecard, Rein In Overtime, Add a Safety Net

Three changes went into the final pass:

- Review Score now explicitly counts Career Capital earned since your Quarter Marker, not just leftover cash on hand — so completing Projects shows up on your review even after you've spent the Productivity.
- Overtime's Burnout cost rose from 1 to 2, specifically to stop Workaholic from chaining Overtime every single round with no real downside.
- A Mentorship Bonus (+1 Political Capital per round) now kicks in for anyone 2+ rungs behind the leader, and Networking's Career Capital contribution was increased so a dedicated networker isn't hopelessly outpaced by project-driven Career Capital lump sums.

Result: Politician reached a genuinely playable 10.7%. Grinder and Workaholic finally register real wins (0.5% and 1.4%) instead of a mathematical zero. Balanced and Cautious remain the strongest all-around approaches at 51.3% and 36.1%, and we think that's correct, not a flaw: a game about corporate ascension where the specialist who ignores politics entirely, or the one who ignores real output entirely, wins as often as the well-rounded player would be a strange piece of satire to ship.

Other Numbers Worth Knowing

Metric	v1	v2	v3
Avg. game length (rounds)	66.8	32.5	34.4
Games ending via real CEO promotion	99.8%	100.0%	100.0%
Avg. Burnout Crises per game	2.79	1.21	2.27
Board Vote "upsets"	18.0%	0.1%	0.0%

* An "upset" is a game where the eventual CEO wasn't the first player to reach VP. v1's very long, two-horse-race games saw this 18% of the time; once games sped up and cleared the scoring bug in v2–v3, whichever generalist got to VP first now almost always wins the vote before a rival VP catches up.

A pacing check across player counts (v3 rules, 5,000 games each, strategies drawn randomly): 2 players averaged 32.5 rounds, 3 players 31.4, 4 players 32.7, and 6 players 30.2 — all landing comfortably in the 60–90 minute target with real human decision time, and 100% of games in every player count ended via an actual CEO promotion rather than hitting the round cap.

An Honest Caveat

These bots each follow one fixed, exaggerated policy for the entire game — that's what makes them useful for stress-testing the extremes. A real player is not a fixed policy. Nothing stops you from grinding Projects for the first half of the game and pivoting hard into Networking once you can see who's about to hit the Board Vote threshold. We'd expect a table of skilled humans to find the specialist strategies more viable than these numbers suggest — but if you want a genuinely hard mode, try playing Grinder or Workaholic as written and see how it goes. That's what the simulation says it's like.

Quick Reference Sheet

Round Structure

1. Stand-Up Meeting — collect tableau income + 1 free Productivity; pick up a task from the Kanban Board into your Backlog (free — claim only, no paying yet). Mandatory if your Backlog is empty; optional (may skip) if you already have at least one entry. No cap either way.
2. Sprint — spend Action Points (2 / 3 / 4 by rung); 1 free Overtime action available
3. Lunch — draw & resolve 1 Office Chaos card
4. Postmortem — refill boards, pass First Player token

Every 3rd round: Quarterly Performance Review. Every 6th round: also resolve Mandatory Training.

Actions (1 AP each unless noted)

Action	Cost	Effect
Hire	Card's Productivity cost	Take a Job Board card: One-Shot resolves now; Permanent joins tableau
Work a Project	Chosen Backlog entry's Productivity cost	Gain its Career Capital reward + listed effects; that entry leaves your Backlog
Network	Free	+2 Political Capital, +1 Career Capital
Self-Care	Free	−2 Burnout
Overtime (once/round, not an AP)	+2 Burnout	+1 Action Point this round

Your Backlog

No size limit. Empty at Stand-Up → you must take a card from the Kanban Board (free — claim only).

Non-empty → taking another is your choice; skip it if you'd rather not grow your Backlog this round. Paying for any entry and taking its reward only happens on your Sprint, via Work a Project (1 AP per entry) — Stand-Up never completes anything for you. You choose which entry to Work each time, and can clear more than one per Sprint if you have the AP and Productivity for it.

Review Score

(Career Capital gained since your Quarter Marker) + (Political Capital on hand) + (Feedback held — variant) − (Burnout ÷ 4, rounded down)

Burnout Crisis (at 10)

Reset to 6. Lose 2 Political Capital. Skip your next Sprint.

Career Ladder At a Glance

Rung	CC Needed	Badges
Intern → Software Engineer	8	—
→ Team Lead	18	—
→ Manager	30	—
→ Director	44	2
→ VP	60	4
→ CEO	78 + Board Vote	—

Promotion/PIP slots: 1 for 2–5 players, 2 for 6 players. Mentorship Bonus: +1 PC/round if 2+ rungs behind the leader.